She's gone.

No, she's hiding.

She's dead.

No, she's playing *dead.*

Then, one morning, it was time. Back to London. I remember nothing about the trip. Did we drive? Did we fly on the Royal Flight? I can see the reunion with Pa, and the aunts, and the pivotal encounter with Aunt Sarah, though it's wreathed in fog and might be slightly out of sequence. At times my memory places it right there, in those horrid first days of September. But at other times memory casts it forward, to many years later.

Whenever it happened, it happened like this:

William? Harry? Aunt Sarah has something for you, boys.

She stepped forward, holding two tiny blue boxes. *What's this?*

Open it.

I lifted off the top of my blue box. Inside was…a moth?

No.

A mustache?

No.

What's…?

Her hair, Harry.

Aunt Sarah explained that, while in Paris, she'd clipped two locks from Mummy's head.

So there it was. Proof. *She's really gone.*

But then immediately came the reassuring doubt, the lifesaving uncertainty: *No, this could be anybody's hair.* Mummy, her beautiful blond hair intact, was out there somewhere.

I'd know if she weren't. My body would know. My heart would know. And neither knows any such thing.

Both were just as full of love for her as ever.

6.